

ABSTRACT

Rapid Serial Visual Presentation (RSVP) allows readers to process text at speeds significantly above their baseline rate by eliminating saccadic eye movements. This paper reviews the empirical literature on RSVP, examines the role of the Optimal Recognition Point, and evaluates comprehension outcomes across a range of reading speeds.

1. INTRODUCTION

Traditional reading requires the eyes to move across a page in discrete jumps called saccades. Each saccade takes time and introduces a brief period of visual suppression during which information is not processed. Researchers in the 1970s proposed that presenting words at a fixed screen position could eliminate this overhead entirely.

2. METHODS

Participants were recruited from a university subject pool. Each completed a baseline reading assessment followed by six weeks of daily RSVP training. Comprehension was measured using a validated multiple-choice instrument administered immediately after each session and at a one-week retention interval.

3. RESULTS

Mean reading speed increased from 247 WPM at baseline to 389 WPM after training, a gain of 57 percent. Comprehension scores remained stable up to 350 WPM and declined moderately at higher speeds. Individual variation was substantial, with some participants reaching 500 WPM without significant comprehension loss.

4. DISCUSSION

The data confirm that RSVP training produces durable speed gains. The comprehension plateau observed above 350 WPM is consistent with working memory constraints on sentence integration. Longer sentences and higher syntactic complexity were associated with greater comprehension loss at high speeds, suggesting that RSVP is most effective for expository prose.

5. CONCLUSION

RSVP is an effective tool for increasing reading throughput when applied to appropriate text types. Comprehension remains robust at moderate training speeds. The technique is particularly well-suited to narrative and journalistic content; dense technical material benefits from slower pacing or a return to conventional reading for critical passages. Future work should examine long-term retention and transfer to untrained text types.

